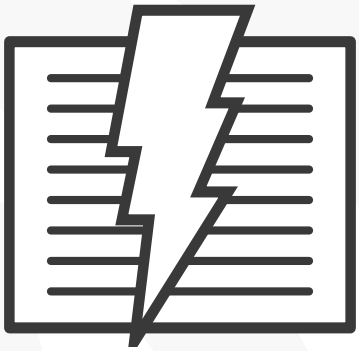

Writing Tips to Supercharge Your UX Work

01 Define and Understand your Target Groups' Needs and Wants

Who is your target group and what motivates them?

You have to be able to answer these questions if you want your future readers to spend time on your text—whether it's a blog post, a book, a chapter, an online course, a news article, etc. Ask yourself these questions:

- Who is your target group? What do they do? What are their Interests, needs, wishes and desires?
- What is important to them? Why should they care about your take-home points?

When you can answer these overall questions, you will be ready to move on to step 2.

02 Find Out What You Really Want to Tell and Why

Step 2 is **by far the most difficult part** of writing. It takes more time than you think, but if you spend sufficient time finding out what you really want to tell, the rest of the writing process will be easy, smooth, and fast for you. And your reader will instantly understand what you want to tell them. It's as simple as that. You should always choose simplicity over complication:

> *"If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it well enough." — Albert Einstein*

Experts tend to live so close to their work that it's hard to see just how complicated those "familiar"

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matters can be to the uninformed eye. While this is an understandable fact, the research and jargon in academia and business can be complicated. Communicating clearly is, on the other hand, very difficult. As Leonardo da Vinci said, "Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication." Very few people are able to communicate the essence and core of the topics they're working on. When you ask them a question, it gets mighty complicated: "There are so many variables" or "It depends," they say. T. S. Eliot said it best: "Where is the wisdom we have lost in knowledge? Where is the knowledge we have lost in information?" Wisdom is timeless and simple. Search for the core and essence of what you're communicating. Search for timeless wisdom and communicate it clearly.

Now it is time to find out **precisely** what you want to teach your target group and why this knowledge is essential specifically for them.

What is the essence/conclusion of your article? And why is it important to the readers? Step 2 is all about **communicating complex topics in a simple and fulfilling manner**.

Whenever you are going to write a new blog post, article, book (and each chapter of that book), or online course (and each lesson item in that course), you should always start the new writing process by **boiling down your main take-home point/conclusion** into:

- "**I want to say that** ... (main take-home point/conclusion),
- **because** ...." (why this is essential to you, my dear reader).

Let's take an example:

- "I want to say that you first have to find out what you really want to tell your reader,
- because this will save you a lot of time and make your text much easier to understand – first and foremost, your reader will instantly get your point; they will find it interesting, and, hopefully, they will be able to use and implement this new piece of knowledge."

Exercise 1: Whenever writing a new article: You have two options

- Start by **writing down** your main take-home point and your motivation to get your point through to your reader.
- Or, say it out loud to your target group, who—you should imagine—are secretly listening to your rehearsal.

We strongly recommend that you do **both**, because sometimes it may sound good in writing, but you can instantly tell that it sounds either too complicated or too shallow when you say it out loud. Sometimes, it is the other way around.

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Exercise 2: Whenever writing a new article: Practice again with your grandmother in mind.

An excellent way to practice this to perfection is to imagine that you will explain your point to your 80-year-old grandmother. She is most likely not part of your target group, but the more simply and concretely you are able to explain yourself, the better you will also be able to explain yourself to your target group.

The two above-mentioned methods sound very easy and quite silly when you read about them, but they are **the toughest and most important parts** of your writing job. So, please don't feel tempted to skip the exercises or continue the writing process until you know that you are 100% certain about your main point and why your readers should care about spending time reading your text. Make sure this really is world-class content and worth knowing for your readers. Don't waste your readers' time. Have respect for them. They only have one (very short) life, and so do you, so please spend it wisely. :)

There is so much meaningless and noisy information out there. We don't want to be a part of that noisy chorus.

03 Hook Your Readers so They Can't—and Won't—Escape

Your headline and your first paragraphs should capture your readers' attention. This is very difficult as there is so much information out there. Most of it is not worth reading. It's just static. You need to be heard above the static and make a difference to your readers instead.

Best practice: You want to let the reader know what to learn and expect from this article right away. That means that you should always:

- **Tell your main point simply and immediately** – and why your main point is essential for your reader. This is the essence of Step 2.
- **You can do this in different ways – while hooking your readers in different ways:**
- Give concrete examples of businesses (or universities) benefiting from your take-home point.
- Find and insert a meaningful **quote**.
- **Provoke** your readers.
- **Surprise** them.
- **A picture is worth 1000 words**. That also applies to a verbally-painted picture or scene. For example, take the subtitle: "Hook Your Readers so They Can't — and Won't — Escape" which makes the point visual, catchy, precise and descriptive.

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- **Ask a meaningful question** which engages the readers and makes them reflect.
- **In medias res**: Take your readers right into the center of your story by vividly describing an essential situation.
- **Reveal something about yourself**—as long as it is interesting and significant in the context and to others, not just to you. At IxDF, we find that this is often not the case, but you could instead reveal something about recognized designers, organizations and businesses.
- **Choose one of or combine several of the above methods** which match your point and target group. Or, come up with an even better hook which matches perfectly in the given context.

You should, of course, continue to insert hooks throughout your text so you continue to engage your readers.

04 Explain and Elaborate on Your Main Point

Once you have captured your readers' attention you should:

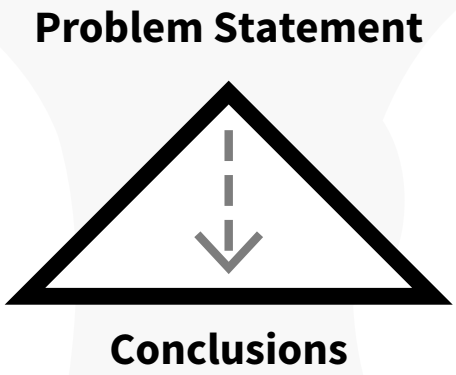
- Instantly tell your main point/conclusion and explain why it is essential to your readers if this is not already a part of your hook. (Step 2)
- The next step is to elaborate on your main point and why this point is essential for your readers by:
  1. going into **details**,
  2. **arguing for and against**,
  3. inserting **different viewpoints and perspectives**; and
  4. providing the readers with **research** on both sides.

The fact that you should always tell your main point and why your point is essential for the reader in the very beginning of your text and then—secondly—go into details is called the inverted pyramid. The reason it is called the **inverted pyramid** is that you tell your main point in your very first paragraphs (the top of the pyramid. After that, you would work your way down into the many details and the major part of your story.

The regular pyramid

In academia, an essay or thesis starts with a foundation and gradually builds to a conclusion in a regular pyramid style. We might write an essay or article using the following structure:

1. Present the problem statement.
2. Bring in related or supporting information.
3. Focus on methodology—How did something occur?
4. Introduce the results.
5. Make the conclusions



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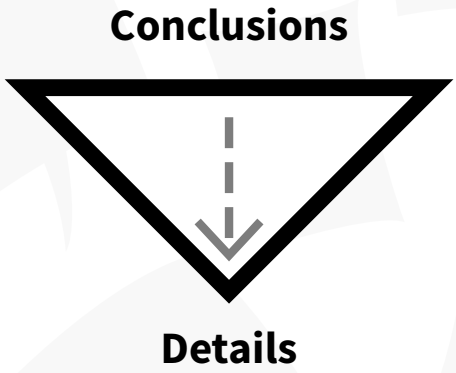
The inverted pyramid



Journalists, on the other hand, use an inverted-pyramid style of writing—and so should skilled educators. They generally start with the main conclusion or outcomes and get progressively more detailed towards the end of the piece, like so:

1. Conclusion or most important information
2. Supporting information
3. Background with (technical) details

Since Web users and email readers typically scan text, using the inverted-pyramid form of writing is a good way to get the most important information in front of your readers first. Position your main points (who, what, when, where, why and the how) at the beginning of the article, and then go into more detail towards the end of your piece.

Source: Yale

Writing with the inverted pyramid in mind can be extremely challenging for an academic writer. I know all about it, as I always struggle with this myself. It is deeply rooted in academic tradition that writers specifically should not conclude anything in the beginning—but only at the very end of a thesis or academic article. Writing with the inverted pyramid in mind is often perceived as poor communication and signifying a lack of expertise in academia. However, when you are not specifically writing an academic thesis or research paper – i.e., when you are writing educational material such as an online course, an article, or an educational blog post – **you should always start out by summarizing the essential take-home point**.

Your readers will trust you. They will believe that you are indeed an **expert**. As they continue reading your detailed analyses, they will either be able to continue to agree with your main point and your expertise or be able to disagree with your perspective in a qualified manner—as you should always seek to bring about different perspectives.

Don't be ashamed about revealing your viewpoint and expertise. Teaching and communicating important topics feels risky because you put yourself and your viewpoints "out there". When teaching, you should take that responsibility and risk, believing that your viewpoints are better than the alternative perspectives. Why would you write a text to begin with if you did not think that you were skilled and able to teach your readers something which would be of great value to them? Of course, you should make it a free choice for your students to pick their own perspective as you give them enough information to disagree with your perspective in a qualified manner. That's because 90% of the content of any particular article/course lesson item/etc. should explain your main point in detail, question your main point and bring about other perspectives

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.Exercise 1: Whenever writing a new article

Please make/write/draw a hierarchy of importance: You should imagine or draw an inverted pyramid where you:

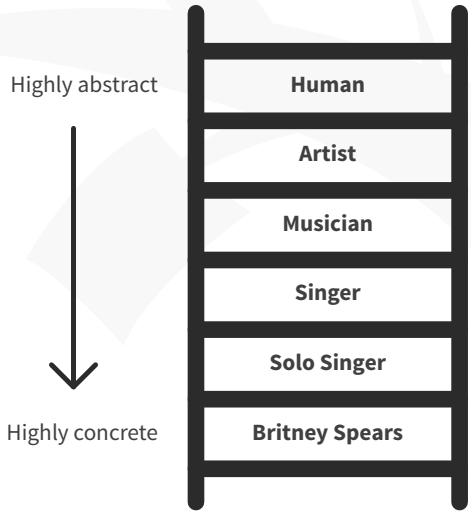
- Write the essence/main take-home point/conclusion first (Step 2).
- Write which details and supporting information are the most important ones so as to explain your essence/take-home point/conclusion.
- Write which details/discussions/perspectives should be at the very end of your article—i.e., the least important ones.

Write in the inverted pyramid style within each paragraph, too: Start your paragraphs with the most important sentence first. In fact, start your sentences with key words as much as you can.

05 Be Concrete and Climb Slowly Up the Ladder of Abstraction

Be concrete. When explaining something intangible and abstract, you should always "**climb slowly up the ladder of abstraction**". Again, I try to paint a verbal picture as my point here is a bit abstract and, therefore, rather difficult to understand and put into use.
The more abstract your topic is—the more concrete you should be. Be concrete, not abstract.

Here is an example of the ladder of abstraction.



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How to be Concrete and Climb slowly up the Ladder of Abstraction

- **Give examples**: e.g., of how the readers can put the insight into use and thereby improve their work lives.
- **Make comparisons**: Just as we compared the concept of abstraction to climbing a ladder in the text above.
- **A picture is worth a 1000 words**. Yet, it is also a verbal picture—again, just as we used the image of a ladder in the text above.
- **Be specific, not general**. E.g., General: "He was a poor designer." Specific: "The designer forgot to create a button which could start the computer." This is closely connected to:
- **Show it; don't tell it**. When you "show" the reader something, the reader can make up her own mind based on your specific description. If you "tell" the reader something, however, you make the general conclusion without sharing the details and reasons. It is also much more interesting to read vividly described scenes instead of plain conclusions. Telling can't take a reader 'there'. "Tell me and I forget. Teach me and I remember. Involve me and I learn." (Source: http://www.funderstanding.com/educational-quotes/)
- "Show it; don't tell it" does not contradict the fact that you should always start your text with the conclusion according to the inverted pyramid. However, you have lots of space to play around with wonderful "showing" descriptions throughout the rest of your text. You can read much more about this at: **Karey Perkins** / **Funder Standing**
- **Exercises**: Create practical exercises whenever applicable, as exercises make the readers reflect on how to put their new insights into use right away. Exercises help them get started improving their work lives. The alternative is most likely that your readers will forget what you just taught them if you don't help them by letting them see and create a link into their own work and practice. If they don't create that really deep-felt link with their own experiences, your work will be wasted and your text will just be a waste of time and another piece of noisy information in each reader's life.
- **Shorter is better**: This is particularly difficult. The more certain you are about your main point and the better you understand it yourself, the more you will be able to explain it to your readers using fewer words. Again, this is why step 2 is always your essential starting point as you find out what you really want to tell and why. Keep in mind that you're aiming for 1000-1500 words.

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- **Redundancy**: Please repeat your take-home points in different ways and several times throughout the text since:
  - this will improve your readers' learning curve as they will otherwise easily forget their new insights; and
  - your readers learn in different ways, so try to explain your take-home point in different ways and give different examples and comparisons which essentially tell the same thing—but, again, in different ways.
- **You are an expert**: Don't be afraid of telling your readers directly what your point is. Being an expert is a vulnerable position to put yourself in, as you reveal your insight and perspectives, thereby putting them at stake. You are here to guide your readers. However, you should never write "I", "me", "mine" but state your arguments in a collective tone such as "we", "us", "designers", etc. You should always provide the readers with alternative perspectives and back up your points with the two following types of knowledge—so the readers will be able to disagree with you in an enlightened and qualified manner.

- Therefore, you should always seek to **integrate the two following types of knowledge** in any piece of content as they both have their advantages and disadvantages:
  - **Industry best practices and methods** and their take on each method/principle/point.
  - **Research, scientific resources and theories** and their take on each method/principle/point in order to validate and discuss each method/principle/point. You should always teach your readers alternative perspectives and viewpoints. Always provide your readers with different sources of research where they can always seek to learn more themselves. Please put the **sources** at the **very end of the article** as we do not want our readers to skip reading the rest of your great article.

The concept of "the ladder of abstraction" was created by American linguist S. I. Hayakawa in his 1939 book Language in Thought and Action.

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06 Seek Inspiration in the Classical Journalistic News Criteria

Although you are not publishing news-oriented journalism, you can learn a few important things from the classical journalistic news criteria:

1. **Identification**: Can the reader or viewer identify with the topic? Are you continually—in your text—making it clear to the reader why she should care? Why is this important?
2. **Actuality**: Why bring the story now?
3. **Relevance**: Why is the topic relevant to your readers?
4. **Sensation**: Personally, I dislike so-called "sensations", but maybe your topic is surprising or exciting?
5. **Conflict**: Does your topic include conflicting viewpoints, or does it contrast the established practices?
6. **Exclusiveness**: Are we the only media or the first media to tell this story?

You should always make sure that your story meets two or more of the criteria. **Identification and relevance** are the most important ones for most content. It is absolutely essential that you always seek to make your topic relevant to your readers, and it is always your job to help them identify with the topic. If therethe topic does not seem relevant—or if the readers can't identify themselves with the topic you are describing—they will not care to spend time reading your text. And they will most likely not learn anything if they do force themselves into finishing your text.

Therefore, you should—of course—make sure to give relevant examples which your readers can identify with. Actually, you should make sure that all the methods mentioned in step 5 (examples, comparisons, pictures, exercises, and research) are chosen with identification and relevance in mind.

Also, you should address your readers directly by writing "you" or "we" whenever you deem that the readers will not feel intruded or offended by it.

References and Where to Learn More

Norman, Donald. **The Four Fundamental Principles of Human-Centered Design and Application**. 2019.

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- How to use human-centered design to solve global challenges
- Why we evolved from User-Centered design to People-Centered design
- The difference between Wicked Problems and Complex Socio-technical Systems
- How to focus on people when you solve complex global challenges
- What feedback loops are and why they are so important
- How to tackle major problems by muddling through and taking small steps to generate successful innovative results

If you understand **why human-centered design is so important**, learn from its history and integrate its principles into your work, you will produce positive results that enhance peoples' lives. It can be done. So let's begin.

Learn more about how you can apply human-centered design to solve complex global challenges in the course **Design for the 21st Century with Don Norman**.

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